



have trained, has a reputation for excellence.

Mahendra tried to hype her up. Although she had been training for a few years at that point, she didn't have much to show for it. Not even a district-level title. Nevertheless, he tried to convince the coaches there that she was a talent waiting to be discovered.

"When I first saw her, I wasn't so sure. She didn't have any real results. And which parent doesn't think their child is special?" recalls Mahavir, a two-decade-long veteran with the Indian national team.

He eventually took the 16-year-old under his wing anyway.

At first, it was just Mahendra who believed in Priya's ability. He'd been an enthusiastic kabaddi player but had been forced by his family to give up the sport and earn a living. While he ran a stone-crushing business in Charkhi Dadri, he retained his passion for sport. To this day, he routinely sponsors kabaddi tournaments in his village. But he

wanted more for his children.

"In my time, no one in my family encouraged me to be a sportsperson. So, when I became a father, I knew I wanted my children to become sportspersons," he says.

Boxing seemed like a good choice.

"When Priya was only three years old, Vijender Singh won an Olympic bronze (at the 2008 Beijing Olympics). He is from Kaluwas, which is only about 20 kilometres from my village of Dhanana. There was a big craze for the sport in the region then. So, I wanted my children to become boxers and win Olympic medals as well," he says.

Priya wasn't the first in her family to pursue the sport. Dhanana has a reputation for producing women's boxers. Two cousins, Sakshi Chaudhary and Nitu Ghanghas, have won titles at the World Championships.

It wasn't clear, though, that Priya would follow in the footsteps of her seniors. She and her brother Neeraj, who is a year and a half older than

her, began boxing in 2016. They initially trained at an academy in Charkhi Dadri, incidentally the same place where shooting Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker had also taken a few classes.

Coach Raj Sangwan remembers Priya as a talented boxer who was good enough to medal at the 2019 School Nationals in Delhi. But not all results went in her favour.

"She took part in district-level competitions but didn't win there. I suspected she wasn't being treated fairly by the judges," says Mahendra.

Despite this, Priya says she never lost her enthusiasm for the sport.

"She always had a *ruchi* (passion) for boxing. Even more than her brother," says Mahendra.

Even at an early age, it was clear that Priya enjoyed the sport.

"On some mornings, training would start at 6am, and there's never been a time that I had to be woken up and told I had to get ready to train. And when I cut weight, I would go out running at 12pm in the